

LEARNING IS FUN

07

Learning English

A group of 15-year-old students chosen from all parts of the country were asked to give their ideas on how they can improve their English outside the classroom. Their responses are given below:

“I think reading is very good for improving our knowledge of the English language. Reading expands your vocabulary. You also learn spelling and grammatical structures.”

Chathura, Anuradhapura

“We can learn English by listening to English radio stations. There are programmes such as discussions, news, debates, and talk shows. Listening trains our ears and helps with our pronunciation.”

Sharon, Colombo

“I listen to English songs and try to sing along even if I don’t know the words. It helps with my pronunciation.”

Fariz, Kalmunai

“I like to write in English. I keep a diary to write about my daily activities. I also write short essays, stories and poems.”

Pubudu, Matara

“I always try to speak with my friends in English. It gives me an opportunity to practice what we learn in the classroom. We make mistakes but we learn from them. Speaking to my friends helps me build my confidence.”

Bimali, Nuwara Eliya

“Watching English cartoons, movies and dramas develop our vocabulary, speaking and listening abilities. We see how English is used in real life situations through these.”

Gowri, Vavuniya

Activity 01

Read the above statments and fill in the following table.

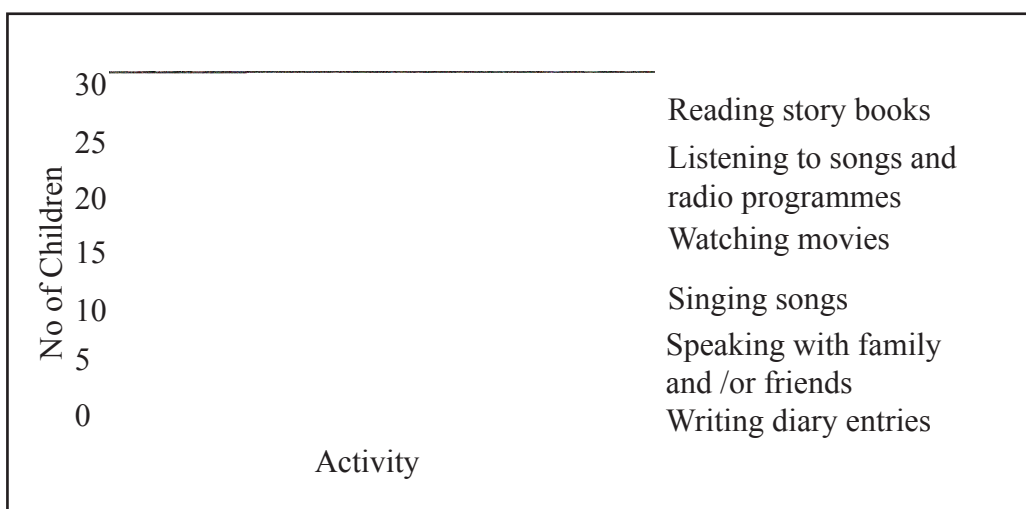
Activity	How it helps to improve your English
Eg. Reading	Improves vocabulary, helps to learn spelling and grammar

Activity 02

Writing

This bar chart shows the results of a survey conducted among 100 grade ten students about their favourite English language related activities. Study the chart and complete the description using the given words.

Activities that students do to improve their English Language Skills



many, most, least, some, a few, activity, equal, number of students

This bar chart depicts favourite English language related activities of a selected group of students. The horizontal and the vertical axes represent the and the respectively.

Out of the given sample of 100 students, of the students read English story books while..... students listen to English radio stations. The number of students watching English movies and those singing English songs are Only students speak to their parents and friends in English while writing in English for daily purposes is done by the number of students.

Activity 03

There are 40 students in Sithum's class. He conducted a survey in his class to find out about the different kinds of story books his classmates would like to read. He recorded the results in the following table. All the students like to read at least one of the three types of stories.

Kind of story	No. of students
Adventure stories only	2
Adventure stories and detective stories only	6
Folk tales only	1
Folk tales and detective stories only	14
Adventure stories and folk tales only	9
All the three types of stories	3
Detective stories only	 ?

- Copy the Venn diagram into your writing book and name the sets of the Venn diagram and record the given data.
- How many students like only detective stories?
- Write a small paragraph describing the Venn diagram.



Fables

A fable is a short story conveying a moral or a message. The characters in a fable often involve animals acting and speaking like people. However, all fables do not feature animal characters.

Activity 04

Reading

Read the fables and select the moral that is most appropriate for each story.

The Two Frogs (A Greek fable-Aesop's)

Once there were two frogs living in a marsh. Unfortunately, during one hot summer the marsh dried up. One frog sorrowfully said to the other, "We have been living in this marsh happily, but we can't live here anymore. We have to find another place to live." So they left the marsh to look for another place to live. After a tiring journey they came to a deep well which contained a lot of water. One of the frogs said to the other "This is indeed a good place. Let us jump right in." But the other frog replied, "I do not think so. How would we get out if this well dried up like the marsh?"

- a) *Think before you leap.*
- b) *Appearances are deceptive.*
- c) *Things are not always what they seem.*

Plucking up a Crop to Help it Grow (A Chinese fable)

Once there lived a very impatient man. He did not like to wait for things to happen in their natural course. He always expected results too quickly. He went to his field every day. The growth of the crop was too slow for him. "I have been waiting for such a long time. My crop has not grown much," he thought. "I must do something to make it grow faster." As a solution he pulled the plants up a little. They looked slightly taller. The man went home happily thinking he had helped the growth. But, on the following day, he saw that his entire crop had died.

- a) *Think before you leap.*
- b) *Quality is better than quantity.*
- c) *Patience is a virtue.*

Honour, Fire and Water (A French fable)

Once, Honour, Fire and Water started on a journey to find new things and new places. After sometime, they realized that they liked to see different things. “We have been travelling together until now, but we might go in different ways. We must make plans about how to find each other,” Fire said. The others agreed and began to make plans. Fire said that they could always find him by his smoke. Water told them to look for signs like green vegetation and evening mist. But Honour apologetically said, “You have to keep me with you all the time. If you lose me once, you will never be able to find me again.”

- a) *Don't be sorry for what is lost forever.*
- b) *Honesty is the best policy.*
- c) *Once you lose your good name, it is difficult to earn it again.*

Education of the Young Lion (A Russian fable)

Lion, the King of the jungle wanted to find a teacher for his son. Fox, though clever, was a liar. Mole was methodical and careful, but he lacked foresight. Panther was a brave fighter; but he did not know anything about the law of the jungle or its politics. No animal was fit to be the teacher of the prince.

One day he found his old friend Eagle, the monarch of the birds. “I have been trying to find a teacher for my son, but none of the animals are wise enough,” Lion said. Then Eagle, as a favour to his friend, offered to teach him. The lion was overjoyed. His son would be learning from a king. He sent the young lion with Eagle to be educated.

Time passed. The young lion finished his education and came home. “The whole kingdom has been waiting for your return,” said the father. “Now tell us how your education has prepared you for kingship.” “Father, I know about all the needs of every bird, said the prince. “I know about the seeds they eat, eggs they lay and how they find food and water. I can even teach our animals how to build nests.” The old king shook his head sadly. He realized that his son had not been taught what he needed most; the needs and interests of his own people.

- a) *Education which does not prepare people to serve their society is fruitless.*
- b) *A hero is brave in deeds as well as words.*
- c) *Try before you trust.*

Activity 05

Speaking

Get into groups. Select one of the above fables and act it out in the classroom.

Learning Point

Present Perfect Continuous

Read these sentences.

- We **have been travelling** together until now.
- The whole kingdom **has been waiting** for your return.
- I **have been trying** to find a teacher for my son.
- I **have been waiting** such a long time.

These sentences are written in the present perfect continuous tense. The present perfect continuous tense is used for an action which began in the past and is still continuing or has only just finished.

(has/have) + (been) + (present participle)

Past	Present	Future
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More examples:

- He has/I have been painting the room.
- She has not/hasn't been feeling well.
- They have not/haven't been playing chess.
- Has he/ Have they been living here for a long time?
- Has it not /Hasn't it been raining?
- Have they not/ Haven't they been studying?

Activity 06

Writing

Complete the blanks using present perfect continuous tense.

Eg:

A: I saw your family at the cinema the other day.

B: Yes, we have been going there every weekend.

• A: Your clothes are all wet.

B: I (water) the plants.

• A: Parami (study) all day.

B: Yes, she should take a break.

• A: Your eyes are red. Have you(cry)?

B: No. I (peel) onions.

• The children (dance) for a while now. They look tired.

• A: Madu has put on some weight.

B: Yes, she..... (not -exercise) lately.

Activity 07

Read the following utterances questions and categorise them as given in the table.

Bimal : For how long *has the old lady been living* in that house?

Ryan : Well, *she's been living there for thirty years*.

Vidura : You look really angry.

Ranesh : Yes, *I've been waiting here for the bus for over an hour*.

Mother : You are so dirty. *How long have you been playing in the mud?*

Son : I've just started.

Zubeeda: *Has Himali been sleeping* all this time?

Gowri : *No, she hasn't been sleeping. She has been cleaning her room.*

Affirmative	Negative	Question

Activity 08

Speaking / Writing

Answer the following questions in complete sentences.

- How long have you been living in your area?
- How long have you been going to school?
- How long have you been learning English?
- How long has your father/mother been working?

Myths

A myth is an ancient story which often involves gods, humans and other natural or supernatural events. Myths have a purpose and try to explain the way of the world. Myths are commonly found in both Eastern and Western literature. These two myths are taken from Indian and Greek mythology.

Bhrigu and the Three Gods (An Indian myth)

Once, the great sages* of India held an assembly to discuss religious and philosophical* matters. The following question was raised in this assembly: “Of the three predominating* gods Brahma, Siva and Vishnu, who was the greatest and most worthy of worship?” They went on discussing this for a long time and yet could not reach a conclusion. So they chose the sage Bhrigu to meet the three gods and test them.

First Bhrigu went to meet god Brahma and neglected the proper forms of respect. Brahma very angrily reproached Bhrigu, but when Bhrigu apologized

and asked for forgiveness, Brahma forgave him.

Next, Bhrigu went to god Siva's palace. There too he omitted the forms of respect. Siva became furious and was ready to burn him with his third eye. Bhrigu had to beg for forgiveness and mercy. At last Siva relented and let him go.

Finally Bhigu went to see god Vishnu. He saw that Vishnu was sleeping on the floor and kicked him in the chest. Vishnu woke up immediately and asked Bhrigu if he had hurt his foot. Then he kindly massaged Bhrigu's foot. Upon this, Bhrigu declared Vishnu most worthy of worship because he conquered* with kindness.

Adapted from: Weigel, James.(1993)Mythology, Cliffs Notes. New Dehhi; Kalyani Publishers.pp.35

sages*	One venerated for experience, judgment, and wisdom.
philosophical*	The things related to the study of the fundamental nature of knowledge, reality, and existence,
predominating*	Have or exert control or power
conquer*	Overcome and take control of

Activity 09

Match the words with their meanings.

- assembly - the action of gathering together as a group for a common purpose
- neglect - due regard for the feelings, wishes, or rights of others
- respect - express regret for something that one has done wrong
- reproach - fail or neglect to do

- apologize - extremely angry
- forgiveness - fail to care for properly
- omits - become less severe or intense
- furious - say something in a solemn and emphatic manner
- relent - stop feeling angry or resentful towards someone for an offence
- declare - express to (someone) one's disapproval of or disappointment in another's actions to that person.

Activity 10

Speaking

Groupwork

How do you think the sage Bhrigu has described this incident to the other sages? Prepare the speech and present it to the class.

Orpheus and Eurydice (A Greek Myth)

Once there was a famous musician called Orpheus. He was considered the greatest musician of the time. Apollo, the Greek god of music, admired him very much and presented him with a “lyre,” a musical instrument. No one could resist his music. Humans and gods alike were charmed by his music. It was said that even wild beasts used to sit and listen to him.

Meanwhile Orpheus met a wood nymph called Eurydice. Nymphs were supposed to be minor nature deities who looked like beautiful women. They fell in love with each other and got married. They were very happy. One day Eurydice had the misfortune of stepping on a snake. The snake bit her and she died. Orpheus was heartbroken. He refused to accept that

his wife was dead. Orpheus was a brave man. He decided to go to the land of the dead to bring his wife back. He was not afraid to take on such a perilous journey.

After travelling for a long time, he reached the shores of the River Styx, the river which separated the world of the living and the world of the dead. There, he met Charon, the boatman of the underworld. Charon refused to take Orpheus in his boat. “No one but the dead can enter the underworld”, he said. But clever Orpheus, playing his lyre, persuaded Charon to row him across the river. Then, he charmed Cerberus, the enormous three-headed guardian dog of the underworld with his music. The dog let him pass.

Hades and Persephone, the king and the queen of the underworld were amazed by the purpose of his visit. They were also enchanted by his music and felt sorry for him. “I will give you one chance,” Hades said. He agreed to let Orpheus take Eurydice back. “If you don’t look back until you reach the world of the living, she will be yours. But if you break your promise, she will turn into a spirit again,” Hades warned.

Orpheus agreed and began the journey. But, as he stepped from the cave of the underworld, he became impatient. He turned back to look at his wife. Sadly, Eurydice had not yet fully emerged. At once she sank back murmuring “farewell.”

Adapted from; Cotterell, A.(1997) Classical Mythology. London: Ultimate Editions. Pp 65

Activity 11

Answer the following questions.

1.
 - i. What was Orpheus?
 - ii. Why was Orpheus called a great musician?
 - iii. Who was Eurydice?
 - iv. What happened to her?
 - v. Whom did Orpheus meet on his way to the underworld?
 - vi. How did he convince everybody to let him take Eurydice back?
2. Why was Orpheus not successful? Give reasons for your answer.
3. What lessons can we learn from this story?

Activity 12

Read these sentences and select the words closest in meaning to the words given in italics.

1. God Apollo *admired* Orpheus very much.
i. envied ii. held in high regard iii. feared
2. Both humans and gods were *charmed* by his music.
i. amused ii. fascinated iii. saddened
3. Eurydice had the *misfortune* to step on a snake.
i. bad luck ii. ability iii. fear
4. Orpheus was a *brave* man
i. clever ii. fearless iii. lazy
5. Orpheus was not *afraid* to go to the underworld.
i. shy ii. scared iii. willing
6. Orpheus undertook a *perilous* journey to the underworld.
i. easy ii. challenging iii. dangerous
7. Charon *refused* to take Orpheus in his boat.
i. declined ii. agreed iii. promised
8. Orpheus *persuaded* Charon to row him across the river.
i. discouraged ii. forced iii. convinced
9. Hades and Persephone were *amazed* by Orpheus' visit.
i. astonished ii. saddened iii. made happy
10. Hades and Persephone asked Orpheus the *purpose* of his visit.
i. cause ii. result iii. time.

Activity 13

Work in small groups. You are going to narrate a story to the class. First member of your group will start with the following words. She/he will narrate a part of what happened. After that, each member will contribute by adding a part to the story. Finally, the first member will have to give the conclusion.

Last Sunday, Nisali wanted to go to the library. But

Now write down your story.

Folk tales

A folk tale is a story that originated in a particular culture, and has typically passed on by word of mouth.

Read and enjoy the following folk tale.

Once there was a man who had four sons. They were always fighting with each other. The father was worried and wanted to teach them a good lesson.

When he was very ill and lay dying in his bed, he asked his sons to come to him. When they came, the old father gave them a bundle of sticks and said, “Can you break these sticks?”

Each one of them took the bundle.

The first son tried to break it, but failed. He tried very hard and finally gave up. Then it was the turn of the second son to try his luck. He thought it would be an easy task and picked up the bundle easily. He tried his best to break it, but nothing happened. Then, the third son tried to break it, but he couldn't do anything either.

Meanwhile, the youngest son jeered at his brothers and thought they were very incompetent. He thought he was very clever and took one stick at a time and easily broke all of them.

The old father then smiled at his sons and said, “Children, do you understand what happened? It is always easy to break the sticks one by one, but when they are bundled together, none of you could break them. In the same way, the four of you should always be together. No one will be able to hurt you then.” The four brothers realised what their father was trying to teach them and forgot all their enmity and learnt that unity is strength.

From that day onwards, they never fought with each other and lived together in peace and harmony.

Activity 14

Now answer the questions given below.

1. List out the characters introduced in the tale.
2. Who succeeded in the mission of breaking the sticks? How?
3. What does ‘they’ in the last sentence refer to?
4. Do you agree with this father’s advice? Why?
5. If you had been there, how would you have created a bond between them?
6. Suggest a suitable title for the tale.
7. What is the proverb associated with this story? Complete the activity given in the workbook to learn more proverbs. (Unit 07- Activity 02)

Activity 15

Consider the statement given below. What are your views about this statement? Divide yourselves into two groups- one for the statement and the other against-and hold a class debate.

Reading is a better pastime than watching television	
Yes	No

Activity 16

Read these descriptions and find the relevant story types from the word maze given in activity 10 in your workbook.

- 1) In these stories the main character investigates crimes.
- 2) In these stories characters are involved in dangerous and/or exciting pursuits.
- 3) These stories are about fairies and other magical creatures. They are usually written for children.
- 4) These stories are handed down from generation to generation usually by oral tradition.
- 5) These stories often tell about science and technology of the future.

Sing the song

LION KING 2 Simba's Pride

Music by Tom Snow, lyrics by Marty Panzer & Mark Feldman

Performed by Cam Clarke, Charity Sanoy, Ladysmith Black Mambazo & Chorus

We Are One

Simba:

*As you go through life you'll see
There is so much that we
Don't understand
And the only thing we know
Is things don't always go
The way we planned
But you'll see everyday
That we'll never turn away
When it seems all your dreams
Come undone
We will stand by your side
Filled with hope and filled with pride
We are more than we are
We are one*

Kiara:

*If there's so much I must be
Can't I still just be me
The way I am?
Can I trust in my own heart
Or am I
Just one part
Of some big plan?*

Simba:

*Even those who are gone
Are with us as we go on
Your journey has only begun
Tears of pain, tears of joy
One thing nothing can destroy
Is our pride deep inside
We are one
We are one you and I
We are like the earth and sky
One family under the sun
All the wisdom to lead
All the courage that you need
You will find when you see
We are one
Family, family
(we are one)*

Activity 17

Writing

1. Which of these ideas are conveyed through the song? Mark true (T) or false (F) .

- Life is complex and unpredictable. ☐
- It is easier to bear disappointments together than alone. ☐
- We are stronger when we are alone. ☐
- We must take care of only our family. ☐
- The whole world is one big family. ☐

2. What do you think is the relationship between the two main characters?
Why do you think so?

3. Simba says to Kiara, “Your journey has only begun.” What does it mean?

4. What is the main idea of this song?